

RESERVATION POLITICS IN RAJASTHAN

Rob Jenkins
Birkbeck College
University of London
r.jenkins@bbk.ac.uk

Paper presented at the conference on 'State Politics in India: Political Mobilization and Political Competition,' organized by the London School of Economics and Delhi University, India International Centre, New Delhi, 16-17 December 2004.

Among the questions posed by the organizers of this conference was the following: 'Are there any new issues that have cropped up on the horizon of Indian politics around which mobilization has taken place, or is it more of the same?' This paper examines one such issue in the context of Rajasthan: the movement demanding reservations for 'economically backward' members of the upper castes. The broad objective is to situate this demand – and the response it has triggered – within the context of several unfolding political processes in Rajasthan. It also asks whether quota politics in Rajasthan has followed a unique pattern of development.

The idea of a reserved category along the lines of the Economically Backward Classes (EBCs) is not new, as such. In announcing his government's support for EBC reservations in mid 2003, Rajasthan chief minister Ashok Gehlot stated that he was following Congress party precedent. Gehlot cited the Office Memorandum issued by the Narasimha Rao government on 25 September 1991 specifying a ten percent reservation in government posts for 'economically backward' groups not covered by other quotas. The BJP claims to have supported the idea as far back as 1985, a

resolution having been passed at the Bhopal party meeting of that year. Neither party, however, can claim to have done much about the issue lately.

The issue became a recognized axis of political mobilization in Rajasthan in November 1999, with the formation of the Samajik Nyaya Manch, or Social Justice Front (SJF). It began explicitly to affect party-political maneuvering and electoral calculations in the first part of 2003, as the countdown to Rajasthan's assembly elections – due later that year – got underway.

The Political Origins of the SJF

November 1999 was not an arbitrary point in time. It was the month in which Rajasthan's Jats made good their part of a political bargain, and voted heavily for BJP candidates in parliamentary elections. Two months earlier, in September 1999, at a rally in Sikar, prime minister Vajpayee had announced that Jats would be included on the list of 'other backward classes' eligible to fill quotas reserved for them in central government employment. Gehlot's Congress government ultimately followed suit, adding Jats to the state list. But, as Gehlot would learn, there is little credit to be derived from agreeing reluctantly to do what your political competitors have already done. It did not help matters when it became widely known that Gehlot only matched Vajpayee's support for Jat reservations when pushed by Sonia Gandhi. The 1999 parliamentary election result was a stunning reversal from the previous year's state assembly election, in which Congress ousted the eight-year-old BJP state government by a historic margin: 153 to 33 seats. Congress's parliamentary delegation from Rajasthan was all but eliminated. Jats were an important factor in both the assembly and parliamentary election outcomes.

In Rajasthan's conventional political narrative, the Jats' traditional rivals for influence and prestige are the Rajputs. Rajasthan's Jat leaders often express hostility towards upper castes in general, but special enmity is reserved for the 'Rajput lobby'. Members of each community are quick to refer to conflicts and peasant uprisings of the early 20th century, which pitted Rajput jagirdars against the Jat peasantry. Whatever else about that period may be in dispute, there is no doubt that through the Kisan Sabha movement Rajasthan's Jats took enormous political strides. Nor has it been in question

that the Jats would, over time, continue to consolidate their influence over instruments of state power.¹ As with so many state-level political rivalries (Lingayats and Vokkaligas in Karnataka, Kammas and Reddys in Andhra Pradesh), each community feels victimized, its interests sacrificed in the name of larger state objectives: Rajputs lament their lost lands and titles, while Jat agrarian radicalism sees a predatory state existing on surpluses produced by India's kisans (Jats foremost among them). The recurring Jat political message is of being 'squeezed' between the upper castes, who look down on Jats' perceived rusticity and relatively low (though always contested) ritual status, and the truly downtrodden bahun (landless Dalits, marginalized adivasis, a large range of genuinely deprived OBC groups), all of whom, unlike the Jats, 'at least have the benefit of official sympathy'.²

It surprised no one, then, to discover that, to the extent the SJF was a response to Jat assertion and state acquiescence, the driving force behind its creation was a pair of Rajputs – Lokendra Singh Kalvi and Devi Singh Bhati. Kalvi, a BJP national executive member and son of a now-deceased and very high-profile Rajput stalwart in the state, had been attempting to mobilize on the upper-caste quota issue as far back as the 1998 assembly election. Devi Singh Bhati had a somewhat chequered career as a BJP minister and legislator, but had a strong local machine in the Bikaner region of the state, and had always been a magnet for publicity. Kalvi and Bhati had both felt sidelined by the leadership of the Rajasthan BJP (and by central observers sent from Delhi to monitor state party affairs). 'It was natural', many said, that they would use an organization such as the SJF to increase their state-wide profiles.³ Each leader's objective was to build a visible following that would assist his bid for leadership positions within the party; internal politicking alone had clearly proved insufficient.

The original nucleus of the SJF was drawn from those who had opposed granting OBC status to Jats. The SJF's Rajput-heavy leadership had sought to ensure participation in the new movement by groups representing the 'original' OBCs – those smaller (and far more socially marginalized) castes and communities that stood to lose from Jats

¹ PC Mathur and Iqbal Narain, 'The Thousand Year Raj', in Francine R. Frankel and MSA Rao (eds), *Dominance and State Power in Modern India* (Delhi: Oxford University Press, 1989/90). In an earlier article Mathur had referred to the Jats' insatiable 'power drive', and the likelihood that this determined aspiration for public influence and status would ultimately be realised.

² This characterization of the Jats' political plight was conveyed to me by a former legislator who is active in Jat politics and professional life. Interview, Jaipur, 2 March 2003.

cornering a disproportionate share of the OBC reservations. The SJF leadership's intention was to form something like a 'Jat sandwich',⁴ rendering the fears expressed by some Jat leaders – that they were being squeezed from above and below – more plausible. This strategy was not modeled precisely on the 'coalition of the extremes' approach that Digvijay Singh was said to have been building in Madhya Pradesh,⁵ because the lower extremities, in the form of the Dalit movement, kept aloof, and on the top end, many Brahmins sought to maintain their distance from the movement, even as they participated in agitations, delegations to official meetings, and so forth.

There were of course partisan dimensions to this conflict that went beyond the 1999 election outcome. Bhati and Kalvi were disgruntled members of the BJP even before the party announced its backing for Jat reservations. Kalvi had been excluded from the list of BJP candidates for two consecutive assembly elections. Bhati had been relegated to the margins of party affairs since being asked to leave Bhairon Singh Shekhawat's cabinet under a cloud in the mid 1990s. Both Bhati and Kalvi felt they represented a strong current of unease among upper castes in the party. What seemed to the outside world like a major coup for the Rajasthan BJP – the untethering of the Jats from the Congress in the 1999 parliamentary elections – was, for some elements within the state party, such as Bhati and Kalvi, a source of considerable anxiety. Calculations were in stark zero-sum terms: the need for the BJP to accommodate more Jats in party posts – at all levels of the organizational hierarchy – would mean fewer posts for Rajputs and other upper castes. Unless, of course, other groups could be squeezed, and this seemed unlikely, given the party's all-out efforts to woo Rajasthan's tribal communities – a strategy which subsequently paid off in the 2003 assembly election, and which implied more, not fewer, positions going to tribals.

The irony was that BJP leaders had hoped that the details of the party's Jat-reservation policy announcement would prevent a backlash by upper castes. Jats would only eat into the benefits enjoyed by other OBC groups, thus imposing no net impact on the general/merit quota for state jobs and studentships, the category in which upper castes competed. Many upper-caste leaders within the BJP did not see it this way.⁶ They

³ Interview with a Congress MLA and former minister, Jaipur, 1 March 2003.

⁴ Interview with one of the political leaders of the SJF, Jaipur, 8 April 2000.

⁵ Christophe Jaffrelot and Jasmine Zerini-Brotel, 'in Madhya Pradesh and Uttar Pradesh', in R. Jenkins, *Regional Reflections: Comparing Politics Across India's States* (Delhi: Oxford University Press, 2004).

⁶ Interview with a dissident (and former minister) in the state BJP, Jaipur, 1 March 2003.

were mainly concerned with the *internal party* implications of the BJP's emerging political alliance with the Jats, especially how it might affect their chances for obtaining key organizational or political posts. The issue of government jobs for ordinary upper-caste constituents was, at the level of political calculation, much less a concern for these leaders.

Congress politics appears to have played a role in the SJF's emergence as well. Several political practitioners and observers strongly suspected that Gehlot himself was closely involved with the SJF; others claim to know this for a fact. Whether he was a kind of silent partner in the launching of the effort or whether he acquired some influence later is also unclear. Gehlot is seen to have solid motives for allying with the SJF. First, he would be fomenting discord within the BJP, which as we have seen was a major catalyst for the SJF's emergence. Providing a measure of encouragement for such splinter activities is routine practice among seasoned politicians in Rajasthan, and in most Indian states for that matter. (BJP supporters claim that Bhairon Singh Shekhawat was the master of this tactic, while Congress supporters reply that it was under the tutelage of Congress chief minister Mohan Lal Sukhadia that Shekhawat learned his craft.)

Second, according to an associate who was in close contact with the CM during the second half of his tenure, Gehlot calculated that a last-minute, surprise announcement in favour of the upper-caste reservation demand might allow him to wrong-foot the BJP in the run up to an election campaign, just at the BJP had done to Congress when embracing the Jats' demands during the 1999 parliamentary election.⁷ This was thought an appropriate response to the BJP's poaching on the traditionally pro-Congress Jat constituency. The logic was that the time had come to abandon efforts at appeasing the unappeasable Jats. Much of the Rajasthan Congress leadership had become convinced after the drubbing the party received in the 1999 parliamentary elections that the Jat leadership (especially those associated with the Jat Mahasabha, the key force behind the OBC-status campaign) would never forgive Congress as long as Gehlot occupied the post that Jat leaders were convinced was their due. Congress therefore would counter-poach on the BJP's upper-caste vote by publicly supporting the EBC proposal. Any upper caste support that could be stripped away from the BJP

⁷ Interview, Jaipur, 2 March 2003.

would help to compensate for some of the lost Jat vote. Any Jat backlash against such a move would be limited in practice; any Jats that were going to desert Congress would already have decided to do so by then.

Not only did Gehlot have good reason to back the SJF; he had the capacity to do so. First, he was not constrained by his base among ‘original’ OBC groups from taking an ostensibly pro-upper caste stand. This was because of the *other* element in the SJF campaign: the demand for segmentation of the OBC quota into subcategories, such as backward, most backward and/or extremely backward. In this way small – original – OBC castes could ensure that they would get a pre-arranged share of posts and not be completely squeezed out by the Jats. The original OBC grouping was an electoral constituency that Gehlot had long hoped to convert into a solid voting bloc, and this (often muted, sometimes unacknowledged) element of the SJF programme seemed an attractively flexible way to pursue this goal.

The second factor that made Gehlot able to pursue a strategy of covert support for the SJF was the existence of a longtime Congress-affiliated official with whom Gehlot had maintained contact. Satyanarain Singh Saini – like Gehlot, a member of the OBC-listed Mali community – was long before the 2003 assembly election a driving force behind the SJF. Saini had good reason for getting involved. He had resigned from his position as a member of the Rajasthan Backward Classes Commission (RBCC) in 1999. This was at the time when the state commission was the subject of pressure from various sources, all demanding that action be taken on the case of Jats, Bishnois and others whose claims to OBC status were under review. The central government relied on an existing recommendation of the national backward classes commission to first announce – and then in January 2003 to notify – the inclusion of Rajasthan’s Jats on the central list of OBCs. The state government, increasingly desperate not to have its image too badly dented by this episode, made demands on the RBCC that Saini, and others, found impossible to endure. The RBCC had been conducting field studies on a select group of castes and communities whose cases had been brought to their attention, and which (in the opinion of the commission) required closer scrutiny. The Rajasthan government and powerful Jat and other politicians wanted this process bypassed, or else drastically sped up and ‘steered in the direction of the correct result’.⁸

⁸ Interview with Satyanarayan Singh Saini, Jaipur, 5 April 2003.

This is why Saini said he resigned in late 1999. Once installed as the SJF's key public relations operative and one of its strategists – he described himself as 'the mastermind' – Saini's connection with Gehlot did not go unremarked.⁹

Partisan Reactions and Centre-State Relations

The SJF's first major breakthrough was on 21 May 2003, when Rajasthan's cabinet voted its support for reserving 14 percent of posts in the state administration for members of Economically Backward Classes (EBCs) – poorer members of those castes and communities not already covered by any other quota. The BJP was caught off-guard, with state and national party leaders referring to the Gehlot cabinet's decision as a 'gimmick'.¹⁰ But just four days later, at a previously scheduled national office-bearers' meeting in Jaipur, the BJP's top leadership passed a resolution supporting the idea of reservations for EBCs. While meeting in Jaipur, BJP leaders – including Deputy Prime Minister LK Advani – had met with an SJF delegation, and were reportedly convinced that the party would pay a price at the upcoming assembly elections unless it neutralized this issue.

With a Congress chief minister in Rajasthan and a BJP prime minister in Delhi, it was perhaps inevitable that what was ostensibly a policy issue – but had become a point of partisan contention – would take on a federal dimension. Soon after the BJP leadership resolution in Jaipur, the party's national president indicated that the BJP-led central government would be establishing a commission to investigate the matter.¹¹

In reply, Gehlot wrote an open letter to the prime minister, requesting him to set in motion the process for passing a constitutional amendment. A constitutional amendment was seen as necessary on two grounds. First, the Supreme Court had stated in the Indra Sawhney case that "[a] backward class of citizens cannot be identified only and exclusively with reference to economic criteria." Second, the court

⁹ Interview with Satyanarayan Singh Saini, Jaipur, 5 April 2003.

¹⁰ The BJP's discomfort with the issue continued right up to the assembly election. Rajasthan BJP president Vasundhara Raje Scindia accused Gehlot of trying to 'divide society' by acceding to the demand for reservations for the economically backward among the upper castes, even while echoing the line taken by BJP leaders in Delhi and elsewhere that the idea of a quota for poor members of non-OBC groups was an old Jan Sangh idea. 'Development Will be the Main Issue: Vasundhara Raje', *The Hindu*, 6 November 2003.

¹¹ 'Panel Soon on Quota for Poor among Forward Castes', *The Hindu*, 27 May 2003.

had fixed the ceiling for total reservations at fifty percent. Because Rajasthan's existing reserved quotas already constituted 49 percent, and the proposed fourteen percent quota for EBCs were to be in *addition* to, rather than a sub-quota within, the existing reservations, this would exceed the 50 percent ceiling.

Gehlot's letter was couched in terms of maintaining social peace and ensuring the public's faith in the fairness of the system. Gehlot claimed, for instance, that an expansion of reservations would ultimately 'have a salutary effect on social fraternity'.¹² The problem, Gehlot maintained, was the rising sense of frustration among upper castes who, despite living an economically precarious existence, were denied privileges granted to members of other communities that had received preferential treatment. 'A large percentage of them are equally backward in terms of education and economic levels', Gehlot maintained, and as importantly, the 'marginalisation of the meritorious' had 'thrown out of gear the normal pace of life'.

Gehlot also argued that targeting benefits at the poor was a firmly established practice in India's social policy – particularly in rural development schemes, where Below Poverty Line (BPL) status is used to determine eligibility for a range of benefits. Supporters of EBC reservations frequently cite this argument,¹³ as well as the fact that Rajasthan has the administrative safeguards to ensure that the process of identifying BPL families is done in a transparent fashion through gram sabhas. After deploying these arguments, Gehlot emphasized that 'the ball is now in the Centre's court'.¹⁴

Even as it proposed constituting a commission, and signaled its willingness to introduce a constitutional amendment bill, the central government threw down a challenge to the Gehlot government. Vajpayee stated that because an amendment would require a two-thirds majority, which the BJP-led coalition at the centre lacked, Gehlot would need to convince his party of the merits of reservations for EBCs. Knowing that Sonia Gandhi had reasons to play down the issue on the national stage, Vajpayee politely requested Gehlot to get his party leader behind the issue so as to build a cross-party consensus. Congress leaders claimed that this was just another in a series of 'dilatatory and

¹² All quotes from 'Gehlot Writes to Vajpayee on Quota', *The Hindu*, 28 May 2003.

¹³ Interview, Jaipur, 3 March 2003.

¹⁴ 'Gehlot Writes to Vajpayee on Quota', *The Hindu*, 28 May 2003.

diversionary tactics'.¹⁵ But at least temporarily the ball was back in Gehlot's court. This was where the issue stood – in terms of policy declarations by the state's major parties – when Rajasthan (and three other north Indian states) went to the polls at the end of 2003.

While the SJM had initially called off its stir when both the central and the state governments had agreed to pursue their main demands, not all of the groups allied with this loose coalition were happy. The Rajasthan Brahman Mahasabha had wanted a sub-quota within the OBC category, with the creamy layer excluded at the level of the individual claimant – a far more fundamental challenge to the basis of the existing system. At the very least the Mahasabha wanted Brahmins explicitly mentioned as eligible under the EBC quota that was being discussed. Its leadership dismissed the concessions by both parties as 'an attempt to befool the Brahman community and to gain political mileage'.¹⁶

In general, Gehlot found the upper castes much less easily drawn to the Congress than such groups had been in UP. This was logical: in UP the upper castes had Mayawati, and the BJP's alliance with her, to stoke their anger. The BSP's actions, whenever in power, were designed specifically to break the upper-castes' control over rural society – primarily through appointments to key police and administrative posts.¹⁷ These were very real challenges. Upper caste voters in Rajasthan had fewer reasons to desert the BJP, especially as it was out of power, though BJP *leaders* from the upper castes clearly harbored bitterness about their *own* fate.

In practice, however, the SJF kept the pressure on both parties, particularly the BJP. SJF activists heckled and disrupted Vasundhara Raje's public appearances at many points on the statewide tour she undertook in advance of the election. Indeed, the extent to which the SJF owed its vigour, if not its continued existence, to dissidence within the BJP was revealed at the time of Vasundhara Raje's appointment as party leader and presumed chief ministerial candidate. The SJF became a useful platform for bringing together dissent against Vasundhara Raje's appointment. For the most part, its

¹⁵ Praful Bidwai, 'The Wrong Kind of Quotas', *Frontline*, 20 June 2003.

¹⁶ Interview with a long-time news editor, Hindi daily, Jaipur, 28 February 2003..

¹⁷ Just to add fuel to the fire, there was also the case of Mayawati detaining prominent Rajput leader Raghuram Pratap Singh under the Prevention of Terrorism Act (POTA). Praful Bidwai, 'The Wrong Kind of Quotas', *Frontline*, 20 June 2003

influence was within upper-caste constituencies, rather than among the original OBC-reserved groups, who Gehlot and others had hoped would squeeze the Jats from 'below'.

Assembly Elections 2003

Scrutinizing the 2003 assembly election result, it fair to say that Gehlot was both right and wrong in his strategic choices. He was right that an anti-incumbent vote was consolidating against him, including a significant section of Jats. At no point did he believe reports of his popularity. Not one of the more than thirty political journalists and social movement activists interviewed in Jaipur in February and March 2003 (admittedly several months before the election) thought Gehlot would lose the election scheduled for later that year. At that time, no one was as worried as Gehlot himself was. Much was made – even by those critical of Gehlot's administration on other matters – of the government's successful management of Rajasthan's drought, which began afflicting the state almost from the very beginning of Gehlot's tenure. After a shaky start, the government's response to the drought crisis constituted a solid achievement. But even under the best circumstances, with a relatively forgiving electorate, it is difficult for a government to obtain much political mileage from making catastrophes slightly less catastrophic than they might have been. Banking on drought-management as a vote-winner was impractical.

On the other hand, Gehlot was wrong if he thought that the SJF would mould itself into an instrument through which he could counter the anti-incumbent wave and retain power – by (a) using pledges of EBC reservations to attract upper-caste votes to the Congress, or (b) getting a sufficient number of upper caste voters to desert the BJP for another party, or (c) consolidating the original OBCs angered by the disproportionately large presence among Jats as a proportion of OBC reservation beneficiaries. Though he seized the EBC issue first, as the BJP did with the Jat reservation issue in 1999, Gehlot could not translate this into electoral success in 2003. Perhaps no one could have.

The SJF did end up registering itself as a party and contesting the 2003 assembly elections in more than half of the state's constituencies. SJF leaders claimed

equidistance from Rajasthan's two main parties. The SJF cast itself as an issue-based movement. The SJF's campaign slogan – 'upekshit ko aarakshan, aarakshit ko sanrakshan' ('reservation for the excluded and protection of the rights of the reserved categories') – demonstrates the SJF leadership's concern to encompass both of the issues that could rally support: the new reservations for poor upper-caste people; but also a fairer way of distributing the benefits of the existing OBC reservations so as to prevent Jats dominating this quota.¹⁸

The SJF was unsuccessful in getting anyone other than Devi Singh Bhati himself elected to the legislature. But if Gehlot did indeed 'encourage' the SJF to contest the elections, by providing funding and logistical support, it was in theory not a bad idea. The objective was to siphon (upper caste) votes away from the BJP in as many constituencies as possible. And, indeed, in a few constituencies a Congress candidate's margin of victory over his or her nearest opponent was less than the SJF candidate's vote tally. If these were mainly upper-caste votes that otherwise would have gone to the BJP, as the conventional wisdom would have it, then tying up with the SJF, even informally, was indeed smart politics on Gehlot's part.

For instance, the sitting BJP MLA was ejected from the Lunkaransar seat in Bikaner district. Having lost by 21,000 votes, he could have used the SJF candidate's 33,000 votes. In Dantaramgarh, in Sikar District, had the BJP candidate received the SJF's 19,000 votes, the Congress would have lost this seat as well. In Hindoli in Dausa, a very close contest, the SJF's almost 900 votes, had they gone to the BJP candidate, would have cost the Congress this seat as well. The same is true for Nainwa, where the Congress won; but had the BJP been able to obtain even half of the SJF's 7,500 votes, the BJP would have retained this seat as well. In Sirohi constituency, in Sirohi district, the BJP again lost by fewer votes than the number received by the SJF candidate. In Luni, in Jodhpur district, the Congress incumbent was reelected; the BJP lost 13,000 votes compared to the previous election, and was pushed into third place by the SFJ. In Bhopalgarh, also in Jodhpur district, the Congress retained the seat, but if even a quarter of the SJF votes had gone to the BJP the Congress would have lost.

¹⁸ Interview with Satyanarayan Singh Saini, Jaipur, 5 April 2003.

Sadalpur, in Churu district, was another place where the Congress's margin of victory over the BJP was less than the SJF's vote tally. Even there, however, it is hard to conclude definitively that the SJF made the difference: the sitting Congress MLA had taken office in a bye-election and so arguably had less time than his ruling-party colleagues to make himself unpopular. Analysis by the CSDS/Lokniti election study indicated that voter attitudes about candidates' personal qualities was the only factor cited in opinion surveys that correlated well with voting patterns.¹⁹ Amber, just outside Jaipur, was another constituency where this dynamic may have been at work. The Congress retained its seat, and would not have done so had 6,000 of the 10,000 votes for the SJF candidate instead gone to the BJP. And yet even this may not have been sufficient had not the Congress replaced the sitting MLA with a new candidate – one of the few constituencies in which it did so, something the CSDS/Lokniti data seems to suggest was a serious strategic error.

So it is only in these nine seats that the SJF can be said to have affected the outcome – and even then some optimistic assumptions have had to be made. The point is, however, that the strategy of cultivating the SJF was a sensible precaution and could have paid off had there been a smaller statewide swing against the ruling party. With closer margins between Congress and the BJP, the SJF candidates could well have assisted a far larger number of Congress candidates. Take, for instance, Pilibanga, in Hanumangarh district, where the SJF candidate received 17,000 votes. In most normal elections, this would have been sufficient to tilt an election. Similarly, in Suratgarh, in Ganganagar district, even the 14,000 votes won by the SJF could not stop the BJP candidate – riding an anti-government wave – from wresting this seat from the Congress incumbent. In Nohka, in Bikaner district, the sitting Congress MLA faced a massive reversal of fortune, going from a 14,000-vote margin of victory in 1998, to losing in 2003 by 27,000 votes. In such a circumstance, even the very healthy ten percent of the vote garnered by the SJF candidate was insufficient to halt the wave of desertions from the Congress to the BJP. Neither was the 5,000 votes garnered by the SJF in Sujangarh, in Churu district, enough to prevent the unseating of the sitting Congress MLA. But it could well have made the difference in a tighter race. The same goes for Churu constituency itself. Even in Bayana, in Bharatpur district, where the SJF received 21,000 votes, it could not prevent the BJP wresting the seat from Congress.

¹⁹ Yogendra Yadav and Sanjay Kumar, 'A Strategy of Micro-Management Pays off for the BJP', *The*

So lopsided was the election that the SJF ended up nudging the sitting Congress MLA into third place.

In Karauli, in Sawai Madhopur, the BJP would have won, had it been able to obtain just 400 of the 18,000 votes won by the SJF candidate – which in this constituency was none other than SJF ‘mastermind’ Satyanarayan Singh Saini himself. Even so, the extent of the anti-incumbency wave was such that in this case the Congress could not itself benefit. A BSP candidate was elected. The sitting Congress MLA in Karauli – an Ashok Gehlot antagonist, Janardhan Gehlot – was pushed into fifth place, with a loss of 27,000 votes from his 1998 tally. Using the SJF, and Saini in particular, to help undermine Janardhan Gehlot would have been cold comfort to Ashok Gehlot when it became clear that his government had suffered the biggest electoral reverse in the state’s history. Not even the emergency had brought about such a turnaround.

Sawai Madhopur constituency itself is a revealing example of how the SJF, while impressive in its ability to mount a campaign and elicit significant support in a large number of constituencies, was simply too marginal a force in the state’s politics to affect the larger, structural trends underway. Again, the Congress lost the seat. The BJP got two and half times as many votes as it had in 1998. It won with a very substantial 57 percent of the vote, a big increase on the 41 percent that was sufficient to return a winner from among the larger field of viable candidates who contested in 1998. Indeed, no candidate since 1967 has garnered such a large percentage of the vote in this constituency. The SJF received roughly 4,000 votes, woefully insufficient, given the size of the electoral wave in the making, to provide any relief for the Congress candidate. The incumbent Congress MLA could only have calculated that, in a very tight race, as in 1998, the SJF might be able to drain enough BJP votes to win him the election. The same logic would have held in Mahua, in Dausa district.

The violence of the anti-government wave was probably beyond the reckoning of most Congress politicians and political operatives. The sitting Congress MLA in Mahua won by 10,000 votes in 1998. The defeated BJP candidate was back on the ballot in 2003. With the BJP challenger improving on his 1998 score by 15,000 votes, and the sitting Congressman losing 10,000 votes himself, the SJF’s 5,000 votes could not make a

difference. But it was not unreasonable, prior to the election, for Congress strategists to think that it might.

Interpreting Rajasthan's Campaigns for Reserved Status

Apart from revealing the way in which issues of identity and representation, through the mechanism of reservation politics, become points of partisan conflict, often assuming a centre-state dimension, what else is significant about the movement for upper-caste reservations in Rajasthan? How can the case be interpreted in light of existing understandings of how the politics of preferential quotas has unfolded in India?

Thus far, the analysis has framed the upper-caste reservation demand in the context of the state's prior accommodation of the Jats. But seeing the EBC movement as primarily a *reaction against* Jat assertion is just one of two perspectives that could be adopted. The other – which is complementary to, rather than in competition with, the Jat-Rajput competition explanation – is to recognize what the Jat and EBC movements have in common: both are movements of elite backlash against the political assertion of traditionally low-status groups.

This has happened in other states as well, of course. But while demands for reservation from among well-off intermediate castes, and even among the traditionally privileged twice-born communities, have been witnessed in Uttar Pradesh and Karnataka (and elsewhere), it would appear that Rajasthan has experienced an unusual trajectory. In Rajasthan's distinctive pattern of Mandalization, the elite backlash *precedes* the very subaltern challenge that in theory should trigger it.

Unlike in UP, there are few signs in Rajasthan's electoral politics of accelerated political organization among lower castes. Neither the BSP nor the SP, nor any local Rajasthan counterparts, have been able to emerge as independent champions of subaltern groups. Both parties run candidates and have pockets of strength – particularly in the north and east of the state – but they have made nothing approaching a breakthrough in terms of electoral performance. Rajasthan remains one of the few genuine two-party systems among India's states, and one of the very few in which those two parties are the Congress and the BJP. Some other smaller formations (and independents) have

been active at very local levels. Rajasthan has seen nothing like the lower-caste assertion found in UP or Bihar, and indeed has not even reached Madhya Pradesh levels on this score.

Nor have the mainstream parties in what is effectively a two-party system in Rajasthan accommodated leaders from the lower castes. Christophe Jaffrelot's data indicates this quite clearly. During the period 1980 to 1998, the percentage of OBCs among members of the Rajasthan state assembly was usually around six to eight percent.²⁰ The proportion of OBCs in Rajasthan's parliamentary delegation during the same period tended to hover around the eight percent mark, sometimes rising to twelve percent.²¹ Even more telling has been the representation of OBCs in ministerial posts. In 1980, nine percent of the Rajasthan council of ministers consisted of OBCs. For most of the period since then it has remained at the lower level of around six percent. In 1998, under an OBC chief minister, the Rajasthan council of ministers was just three percent OBC.²²

Given that Rajasthan has remained aloof from the trend of OBC political assertiveness found elsewhere in north India, what is driving this upper caste reaction? As one senior civil servant in Rajasthan put it, 'there has been no "frontlash", so where is the question of backlash?'²³ One argument voiced by people who see the Jat and upper-caste reservation campaigns as of a kind – elite backlashes against threats from below – is that they represent a special variety of backlash: reaction against a phenomenon taking place largely *outside* of Rajasthan's political sphere (and outside its public-sector labour market). These relatively privileged groups are, according to this theory, responding to the lower-caste political assertion that has taken place across the larger north Indian cultural zone of which Rajasthan is a part. Action and political reaction, therefore, occur at different levels of geographic aggregation. Those voicing this view tend to be vague about whether there is anything new, qualitatively or quantitatively, in this fluidity in the level of aggregation at which political demands are articulated or the cross-border political influences that help to generate them.

²⁰ Christophe Jaffrelot, *India's Silent Revolution: The Rise of the Lower Castes in North India* (London: Hurst, 2003), p. 364, Table 10.15.

²¹ Ibid, p. 353, Table 10.5.

²² Ibid, p. 365, Table 10.16.

²³ Interview, Jaipur, 1 March 2003.

This is not a wholly convincing explanation. External influences alone cannot account for why a backlash should have arisen in the absence of the state-level political factors that played such a large role in other states where intermediate and upper castes have waged campaigns to balance the rising power of OBCs and Dalits.

An alternative approach to resolving this apparent paradox – of a backlash without a ‘frontlash’ – is to remain focused on processes of political change underway within Rajasthan itself, but to move beyond the narrow domain of electoral politics. There exist other arenas in which influence is exerted, parallel structures of social and economic domination over which the hold of the upper castes is inexorably slipping. In the case of Rajasthan, this challenge to elite groups is taking place not at the level of organised political parties built around an idea of bahun empowerment, but at the level of *local networks of political influence*. It is a matter for the base of the political pyramid, not its apex; the actors are loosely connected individuals, not political parties.

By far the best systematic evidence of the emergence in Rajasthan of grassroots-level challenges to upper-caste social and political control is found in the work of Anirudh Krishna. Krishna has documented the rise of a new phenomenon in rural Rajasthan: the *naya neta*. These are political fixers *who come increasingly from non-elite social groups*. Krishna argues that the hold of upper castes on the political brokerage function has been broken, and that the emergence of ‘these new non-caste-based entrepreneurs’ is a hugely consequential development in local politics.

The *naya netas* have also become important subcontractors for Rajasthan’s parties, who to a large degree contract out the local political organizing function to these middlemen. *Naya netas* can influence voters on whose behalf they have intervened with officials, or who expect to require such services in the future. Such voters – prospective or existing clients – face strong incentives to vote for candidates their fixer recommends. A candidate who, if elected, will not do business with the middleman you are likely to engage on your behalf is, by definition, unattractive.

Krishna’s study, which is based largely on quantitative data but demonstrates sensitivity to qualitative factors as well, investigates political participation in parts of contemporary Rajasthan and Madhya Pradesh. He is interested in how stocks of social capital get

activated, and the role of political entrepreneurs in this process. His argument is that high social capital, combined with impressive capacity among political entrepreneurs, accounts for increases in participation, because such an environment helps to 'direct participation into channels – such as campaigning, contacting, and protesting – which are normal and healthy...', rather than in less constructive directions.²⁴

Krishna sees these non-elite political middlemen as representing an increasingly important breed of political operative. The naya neta's role is to act as a broker, getting government work done on behalf of ordinary people who need to transact business with state officials for one reason or another – a pension dispute, a land-registration matter, a certificate of domicile, a court case. Naya netas correspond to what in some localities people will call, sometimes with a hint of irony, a 'social worker'. Krishna convincingly renders the sheer grit and hard work exhibited by these ambitious, usually young, non-elite 'fixers', to use Manor's preferred term.²⁵

Krishna traces the widespread emergence of these naya netas back to the great gains in literacy seen in Rajasthan during the 1980s and 1990s. Other factors too difficult (or impossible) to measure may also have played a role in the emergence of fixers from non-elite communities, but literacy is the one variable that correlates most strongly with the changes Krishna's field research has uncovered. Literacy has translated into familiarity with official (written) cultures, and therefore an ability for an ambitious naya neta to make his mark as an administrative middle man, straddling the state-civil society boundary.

Krishna specifically notes that the naya neta phenomenon – and the over-representation of OBCs and Dalits in their ranks – has been a source of irritation to the upper castes. Having new entrants into the market 'has the effect of neutralizing to some degree the advantages for political participation that were possessed earlier by high-caste and relatively wealthy villagers'.²⁶ This sense of dissatisfaction was among

²⁴ Anirudh Krishna, *Active Social Capital: Tracing the Roots of Development and Democracy* (Columbia University Press, 2002), p. 162

²⁵ James Manor, 'Small-time Political "Fixers" in India's State Politics', in Ashutosh Varshney (ed), *India and the Politics of Developing Countries: Essays in Memory of Myron Weiner* (New Delhi, Sage Publications, 2004).

²⁶ Krishna, *Active Social Capital*, p 151.

the public sentiments into which both the Jat Mahasabha and the SJF organizers actively sought to tap.

The extremely interesting findings produced by Krishna's research might be elaborated in two ways.

First, there is a great deal of anecdotal evidence in Rajasthan supporting the notion that rural civic groups in Rajasthan played a major role in facilitating the *naya neta* phenomenon. The many varieties of grassroots organization found in rural Rajasthan – single-issue campaigning groups, local kisan associations, even the much maligned service-delivery NGOs – have served as a training ground for the kind of political operatives Krishna describes. By engaging with the state at many levels, and becoming familiar with the convoluted workings of the rural development bureaucracy, people from non-elite social origins have acquired a range of skills, which they have put to uses other than conventional development advocacy.

Organizations engaged in sizable outreach activities – like the SWRC, Urmul, Astha or Sewa Mandir – all seek talented, resourceful field workers. They must administer large projects, often funded from external sources, and require staff with local knowledge and access to the mainly poorer target communities. Working for such organizations in rural settings usually involves on-the-job training in managing relationships among local people and official agencies. So it is not just literacy itself, but in some cases the large literacy *programmes*, where youthful go-getters often get their first jobs, that have been as important in allowing the lower-caste *naya netas* to emerge.

Interestingly, even though the management of these large development NGOs is usually overwhelmingly upper caste, this does not appear to have led many lower-caste field workers into a professional dead end. It may even have helped them. They have taken up 'social work', and have done very well as a result. Krishna relates the view of a *naya neta* from a lower caste background who attributed his success to the effective networks he built among poorer members of the upper castes. Sounding like an SJF activist, the *naya neta* offered the observation that 'there are many poor Brahmins, you know -- as well as...Rajputs'.²⁷

²⁷ Krishna, *Active Social Capital*, p. 157.

The second point concerns Krishna's account of how increased competition in the 'fixer sector' has affected consumers. The consumer is content to see the *naya neta* phenomenon result in a more competitive market for fixing services, Krishna notes. By overcoming longstanding barriers to entry in a protected market, the *naya netas* are driving down costs, and inevitably competing against one another as well:

'Usually, there is more than one new leader in a village, and monopolistic rents are competed down where they arise. Villagers are free to select which among these new leaders they will use for any particular service, and they are wont to prefer persons who abide by local norms of decent behavior, including rendering neighborly assistance at time of need without profiteering.'²⁸

According to Krishna, because they lack other forms of largesse (the ability to confer social legitimacy, for instance), *naya netas* have an added incentive to avoid the corrupt and high-handed attitudes adopted by more traditional village intermediaries. *Naya netas* from low-caste backgrounds are forced to compensate for their lack of social status or inherited political connections with honesty towards their clients. The *naya netas* '[a]cquire status and respect in their village by working seemingly selflessly on behalf of their neighbors – and status and respect are important motivations for people who hail mostly from quite humble origins.'²⁹

The concern is that Krishna may overstate the extent to which this new breed of fixer operates free of the constraints of systemic rent-seeking. Groups actively seeking to combat corruption in rural Rajasthan share Krishna's belief that more OBCs and Dalits are becoming influential political intermediaries, and that this is shaking up local politics; but the idea that these political entrepreneurs are any less entrepreneurial in exploiting their role as middlemen – both for direct pecuniary gain and to secure their positions – was greeted with a great deal of skepticism.³⁰

²⁸ Ibid. p. 49. Movement groups operating in central and southern Rajasthan have disputed the intensity of the competition effect, and when presented with the evidence provided in Krishna's text, derided the claims about 'neighbourly assistance'. The dynamics, they argued, were far more ruthless and mercenary.

²⁹ Krishna, *Active Social Capital*, p. 49.

³⁰ This is emerged in interviews conducted during March 2002 and February 2003 with leading figures in three high-profile Rajasthan-based movement groups.

There are also logical grounds for questioning how far competition and a thirst for honour – even as a marketing strategy in a competitive business – could allow political operatives to cut against the grain of systemic corruption. Krishna argues that because consumers are free to choose their fixer, they go with the more honest brokers. But this competitive dynamic is at odds with Krishna's portrayal of the *naya netas*' relationships with aspirant politicians and political parties, where the *naya netas* appear to have all the leverage:

'One would expect parties and new village leaders to have symmetrical relations based on mutual dependence, for each has some resources – followers and votes in the case of village leaders, and access to development benefits in the case of parties – that the other side covets. But relations between parties and new leaders are hardly symmetrical in practice, especially in villages where the community is bonded together by strong structural and cognitive bonds – where social capital is high – and where village leaders are more knowledgeable and skillful at brokering deals.'³¹

Thus the ability of a *naya neta* to extract redeemable promises of benefits from parties and politicians rests on his ability to *deliver* a consolidated village vote. Villages 'that are more close-knit and better led mobilize more often and in larger numbers – and they also set the terms for these engagements' with parties, who exchange promises of future assistance for votes. The two variables – the skill of the political entrepreneurs and local social capital – are seen as dynamically linked: 'The new leaders' capacities to mobilize villagers and to deliver collective benefits are influenced critically by the level of social capital in a village'. Villages with a 'tradition of acting together for mutual benefit...are more likely to' bargain successfully for benefits from party leaders. Krishna is, in effect, arguing that the promise of bloc voting is the currency that villages endowed with more social capital are able to offer, and parties must compete to buy it. A skillful political entrepreneur uses this situation to secure a good price – in terms of commitments of patronage resources – for the village as a whole.

The problem is that the image of a unified village, in which people rally around the candidate or party recommended by a single fixer who speaks for their collective interest, is hard to reconcile with the hyper-competitive market for fixing services that is alleged to keep levels of corruption in check.

Conclusion

This paper has been a very preliminary attempt to analyse the politics underlying the demand for reservations for poor members of Rajasthan's upper castes. It begins outlining a case for seeing Rajasthan's political trajectory in the post-Mandal era as somewhat distinct from that experienced by other states. In particular, the backlash from the upper castes is not being driven by the conventional cause – increased electoral penetration by autonomous Dalit and OBC parties. In Rajasthan, a key catalyst was arguably the gradual erosion of upper caste control over *informal* political structures that operate at the front-line of practical politics. The networks through which a new breed of (disproportionately lower-caste) political entrepreneurs exert influence on behalf of clients have taken shape largely thanks to the continuously expanding rural development bureaucracy (a factor Krishna notes), but also as a result of purposive action on the part of non-party political formations of various types: service-delivery agencies, advocacy groups, grassroots peoples' organizations (a factor that Krishna underemphasized).

The Rajasthan case may also suggest that reports of the death of distributive politics may have been greatly exaggerated. In May 2004, Pratap Mehta argued, in a speech to the Washington-based Ethics and Public Policy Center, that following the 'effective death of populism in Indian elections' – because the state is bankrupt and voters do not believe promises of giveaways anymore, presumably whether these come from old netas or new netas – parties were faced with three main options for crafting a social coalition: the redistributive paradigm, the regional identity paradigm and the Hindu nationalist paradigm. Each of these three has also, for various reasons, hit its limits, Mehta tells us.

'Redistribution through greater representation' is just one of three types of redistributive politics (land reforms and direct wealth transfers being the other two). Mandalization clearly falls into this subcategory. Mehta sees the politics of preferential discrimination as having hit a classic limit: 'there is no point pressing for large numbers of reservations when the size of government is not going to expand as rapidly....'.³²

³¹ Krishna, *Active Social Capital*, p. 161.

³² 'The Indian Elections: Counting the Votes and Assessing the Stakes', Event Transcript of an address by Pratap Bhanu Mehta, Ethics and Public Policy Centre, Washington, DC, 11 May 2004, www.eppc.org.

This is a common view, and has clear merits for anyone who is realistic about the future of India's economy. But Rajasthan's recent experience also raises the possibility that there is more life left in reservation politics than we might think.

First, and perhaps most importantly, the Indian state has in recent years experienced a large increase in employees in one occupational category: people's representative. With the consolidation of the third tier of elected government in the 1990s, local government structures have proliferated (most states having three levels), as have the people who occupy them. So because reservations apply to seats in panchayati raj institutions, and because these seats are increasingly vital to the discharge of governmental authority, reservation politics – seeking to determine who is included and who is not – will continue to be a political focal point. The Jat reservation campaign in Rajasthan was primarily motivated by the desire of Jat leaders to ensure that in district councils where they held a majority, the presidentship was not out of their reach because it was reserved for OBCs.

Second, reservation systems can be endlessly tweaked. Proposals for excluding the creamy layer from among OBC beneficiaries take many forms, and much heated debate is devoted to the issue of which proposal is most suitable for a given state's political environment. It may seem futile for social groups to seek ever-smaller segments of a pie that is itself shrinking, but that does not mean their leaders will not convince people that it is worth doing anyway. Moreover, each small change to the rules can trigger further demands. Rajasthan's Gujjar community asked to be moved from the OBC to the Scheduled Tribe list following the inclusion of Jats in the OBC list and their subsequent domination of this quota. Were the Gujjars' wish to be granted, a counter agitation from within the ST community would likely ensue.

Of course, another view is that Rajasthan offers confirmation for Mehta's thesis, rather than ammunition against it. After all, the SJF was unable to make much of an impact on the electoral outcome. 'Redistribution through representation' may have run out of political steam. On the other hand, in a close election, the SJF would have made a possibly decisive difference. Political leaders will always be planning on a close election.

